

BODY SIGNS



GOALS

IN THIS UNIT, YOU WILL:

- Read about the power of nonverbal communication.
- Learn how we can use our bodies to change our attitudes.
- Explore low- and high-power poses.

THINK AND DISCUSS

1. What are some examples of body language?
2. What kinds of messages do we send through our body language?



Medalists celebrate at the 2014 Winter Olympics in Sochi, Russia.

Lesson A

PRE-READING

- A.** Look at the photo of Usain Bolt and read the caption. How do you think he feels? How do you know?

Answers will vary. Possibilities include: triumphant, victorious, happy, joyous, strong, powerful, proud, etc.

- B.** Look at the infographic on page 96. Discuss these questions with a partner.

1. Which of the poses matches the one Usain Bolt is doing?

Bolt is making a tall-and-proud pose that shows strength.

2. What do you think the graphic tells you about how different poses make us feel?

The infographic shows us how people see us and how we view ourselves while using various non verbal expressions.

C. Look at the title of the passage. What do you think “power poses” are?

- a. How you hold your body when you win a big prize
- b. How you exercise at the gym to make your body strong
- ☒ c. How you sit or stand to show how powerful you are

D. Skim the passage quickly. What kind of reading passage is this? How do you know?

- ☒ a. An article about some research
- b. A report about a news event
- c. A personal narrative

In skimming, students should note that each paragraph begins with information and evidence about the research. Students should also pick up vocabulary that helps them infer that the topic is research.

Usain Bolt reacts after winning a gold medal at the 2014 Commonwealth Games in Glasgow, Scotland.



**POWER
POSES**



POWER POSES

Amy Cuddy, a social scientist and TED speaker, studies body language (or *nonverbal communication*). She is particularly interested in nonverbal expressions of power. This is what our bodies do when we are—or feel—powerful. Cuddy believes that by changing our body language, we can change how powerful we feel.

To **prove** this point, she ran an experiment. First, she invited a number of candidates to be interviewed for a job. Next, immediately before the interview, Cuddy asked half the candidates to practice high-power poses for two minutes. The other candidates were asked to practice low-power poses for two minutes. Then the interviews were filmed and later watched by a panel of interviewers who were not told what the experiment was about. The panel judged the candidates who had practiced the high-power poses very **favorably**. However, the interviewers did not want to hire anyone who had done the low-power posing.



Cuddy gives a simple, biological explanation for this. She says that striking some poses **releases** particular chemicals in the brain. For low-power poses, these chemicals make people believe they are powerless. Feeling powerless, they often do not **cope** well with **stress**, and they are less positive. **Conversely**, Cuddy found that high-power poses release other chemicals in the brain. These tell people that they are powerful, so they then feel **confident**. Interestingly, Cuddy found that it didn't matter what **qualifications** a candidate had, or even what he or she actually said in the interview. "It's not about the content of the speech," explains Cuddy, "It's about the presence that they're bringing to the speech."

Cuddy's research suggests that doing a high-power pose for two minutes—even if we might look a bit silly when doing it—may make us feel more powerful. Feeling more powerful may very well make us *believe* we are more powerful. And that belief has the power to change our lives.

candidate: *n.* a person who applies for a job

presence: *n.* a way of behaving—for example, a way of standing or sitting or speaking—that makes a person memorable to others

HOW PEOPLE SEE YOU, HOW YOU SEE YOURSELF

We all know that our body language affects how people see us. But does it also shape how we see ourselves? In her TED Talk, “Your body language shapes who you are,” social psychologist Amy Cuddy discusses how our posture can affect testosterone and cortisol levels in the brain and change our feelings about ourselves. That means that standing tall and proud—even when we don’t feel confident—can have a positive impact on how we’re perceived. So take a look in the mirror; your next success could depend on how you pose.



PROTECTIVE

Placing your hand on your face or neck is a low-power pose that communicates a need for protection from other people.



HAND-HIDING

Hiding your hands in your pockets is another example of a low-power pose; it hints that you may lack self-confidence.

“...Change your posture for two minutes... It could significantly change the way your life unfolds.”
– Amy Cuddy

HOW PEOPLE SEE YOU

WEAK

STRONG

HOW YOU SEE YOURSELF



WONDER WOMAN

Shift your pose to make yourself appear bigger. That can take you from looking meek to seeming assertive.



TALL AND PROUD

Take a private moment to hold your arms up in a V-shape and lift your chin. That can make you feel (and seem) powerful.



A swan stretches its wings. Many animals use body language to show power by “opening up” their bodies.

Developing Reading Skills

GETTING THE MAIN IDEAS

Use the information from the passage on pages 94–96 to answer each question.

1. What is the passage mostly about? Choose the best answer.

- a. Some people are naturally powerful.
- b. We can change how powerful we feel.
- ☒ c. Power makes it hard to cope with stress.

2. What did Cuddy's experiment show? Complete the sentences.

a. Power posing can have a significant effect on

the way we view ourselves and are viewed by others

b. After doing low-power poses,

people performed well in an interview

c. After doing high-power poses,

people didn't perform well in an interview

GETTING KEY DETAILS

A. Choose the best word or phrase to complete each sentence below.

1. According to the reading passage, it **may be** / **may not be** possible for everyone to feel more powerful.
2. The panel that viewed the interviews were **told** / **not told** about the power poses.
3. The ~~candidates~~' qualifications made **a very big difference** / **no difference at all** in the experiment.
4. The results of the experiment are explained by chemicals in the **brain** / **muscles**.

B. What other term does the passage use that means the same as *body language*?

nonverbal communication

RECOGNIZING THE STRUCTURE OF A TEXT

Some expository texts explain a piece of research. These texts usually follow the same logical flow. First, the writer states the question that the researchers studied and shares the researchers' prediction about what they will find (the hypothesis). Then he describes what research was done (the method) to try to support the hypothesis. Next, he explains the results of the research and states if the hypothesis was supported or not.

A. Match the parts of the research process with the passage excerpts below (1–4).

conclusion hypothesis method results

1. "To prove this point, she ran an experiment." method
2. "Feeling more powerful may very well make us *believe* we are more powerful. And that feeling has the power to change our lives." conclusion
3. "Cuddy believes that by changing our body language, we can change how powerful we feel." hypothesis
4. "[T]he panel judged the candidates who had practiced the high-power poses very favorably." results

B. Using the information from the passage, complete the chart about the results of Cuddy's experiment.

High-Power Poses



Chemical released in brain:



Tell a person he or she is powerful.



Person feels confident.



Interviewers respond positively.

Low-Power Poses



Chemical released in brain:



Tell a person he or she is powerless.



Person feels stressed and less positive.



Interviewers respond negatively.

BUILDING VOCABULARY

A. Complete the text with the correct forms of the words below.

confident

cope

release

stress

My brother, James, has to give a presentation at a conference next week. He's not a very stressed experienced public speaker, so he is feeling very right now. But he's trying a new strategy to cope better with public speaking. He is practicing power poses. By standing with his arms above his head, he releases chemicals in his brain. This makes him feel more confident. I hope he gives a good presentation.

B. Match each word (1–4) with its definition (a–d).

b 1. conversely

a 2. favorably

d 3. prove

c 4. qualifications

a. positively

b. in contrast

c. skills, capabilities, or experience

d. to show that something is true

CRITICAL THINKING

1. **Analyzing.** What do you think Cuddy means when she says, “It’s about the presence that they’re bringing to the speech”?

She means the energy and manner with which they present themselves to others.

2. **Personalizing.** Think of a famous person or someone you know in real life whose body language makes them seem powerful. What do they do specifically? How do other people react to them?

Answers will vary.

EXPLORE MORE

There are many online resources about using body language to feel and become more successful. What kinds of nonverbal expressions can have negative effects? Share your findings with your class.

YOUR BODY LANGUAGE SHAPES WHO YOU ARE



AMY CUDDY Social psychologist and academic, TED speaker

Amy Cuddy was involved in a serious car accident when she was a student, and doctors believed she would not be able to complete college. But Cuddy prevailed, and that experience taught her a lot about persistence. Now she is a professor and social psychologist at Harvard Business School.

The challenges that Cuddy faced when she was a student have made her keenly aware of her own students' attitudes and feelings. In her classes, she observed important differences between the body language of the male and the female MBA students, and the implications those differences had on student success rates.



These observations led her to research power dynamics based on nonverbal communication—how we judge others and how we are judged without saying a word. Cuddy’s work caught the public’s attention. Her TED Talk on the subject has been viewed more than 20 million times.

prevail: *v.* to succeed against the odds

implications: *n.* possible future results or effects

Cuddy's **idea worth spreading** is that by 'power posing' for two minutes, you can actually feel more powerful.



In this lesson, you are going to watch segments of Cuddy's TED Talk. Use the information about Cuddy on page 100 to answer the questions.

1. What happened to Cuddy when she was a college student?

She was involved in a car accident.

2. What did she notice at Harvard Business School?

Her male MBA students had different body language from her female students, and were more successful.

3. Why do you think Cuddy's TED Talk has been so popular?

Answers will vary. It is a topic that crosses many disciplines and areas of life. Cuddy offers some easy ideas about improving your power, which may appeal to many.

PART 1

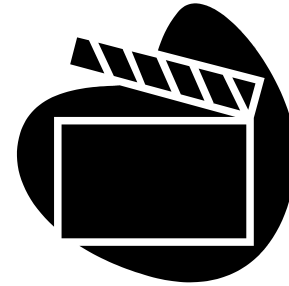
JUDGING OTHERS AND OURSELVES

PREVIEWING

A. Read this excerpt from Cuddy's talk. Choose the statement below that provides the best summary.

“So social scientists have spent a lot of time looking at the effects of our body language, or other people's body language, on judgments. And we make sweeping judgments and inferences from body language. And those judgments can really predict meaningful life outcomes, like who we hire or promote, who we ask out on a date.”

1. Social scientists judge people based on their body language.
2. We make judgments about one another based on our body language.
3. Businesses are hiring social scientists to help them choose their employees.



GETTING THE MAIN IDEAS

Watch (▶) the first segment of the talk and answer the questions below.

1. Why do you think Cuddy shows the photos of famous politicians? Note down some ideas and then discuss with a partner.

She is showing what body language can reveal about someone and how it can change our perception of that person.

2. What does Amy Cuddy mean by *interaction*? Choose the best definition.
 - a. Talking to, or doing things with, other people
 - b. The way you feel about something that was said
 - c. Feeling happy about something you did or said

3. Cuddy mentions two areas of our lives on which body language can have an effect. What are they? Complete the sentences with your ideas.

The first is how we judge others.

The second is how they judge us.

4. When Cuddy talks about “the other audience” that is influenced by our nonverbal communication, who does she mean? Discuss with a partner.

She means ourselves. The way we think about ourselves is also influenced by our body language.

CRITICAL THINKING

Reflecting. Can you think of moments in life where people may judge us based on body language? Note down your ideas and then discuss with a partner.

Answers will vary. Cuddy focuses especially on public presentations.
Other possibilities include: meeting people for the first time, dates,
or job interviews.

FAKE IT TILL YOU MAKE IT?

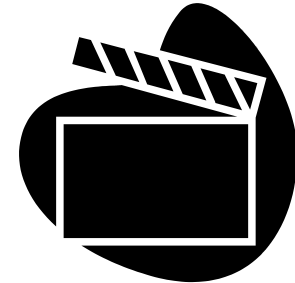
GETTING THE MAIN POINT

- A.** Read the excerpt from the next segment of Cuddy's talk. What do you think the question "Can you fake it till you make it?" means? Discuss with a partner.

"So, my main collaborator, Dana Carney, who's at Berkeley, and I really wanted to know: Can you fake it till you make it? Like, can you do this just for a little while and actually experience a behavioral outcome that makes you seem more powerful?"

To "fake it till you make it" means to pretend to be good at something until you actually are.

- B.** Watch (▶) the next segment of Cuddy's talk.
Complete the sentence about Cuddy's main point.



When you pretend to be powerful, _____.

- a. most people will realize you are faking
- ☒ b. you are more likely to feel powerful
- c. other people around you will feel powerful as well

CRITICAL THINKING

Inferring. What can we infer about risk tolerance from the results of the experiment?

People who feel powerful have a higher tolerance for risk.
Confident people are more comfortable with risk.

PART 3

OUR BODIES CHANGE OUR MINDS

RECOGNIZING SEQUENCE



A. Read the statements (a–g) about Cuddy’s story. As you watch (▶) the final part of the talk, put her story into the correct order (1–7).

- 4 a. She begins graduate school at Princeton under Susan Fiske.
- 7 b. Cuddy fakes it . . . and she makes it!
- 2 c. Her IQ level drops, and she is told she won’t be able to finish college.
- 6 d. Her advisor won’t allow her to quit and insists that she fake it.
- 1 e. Cuddy is involved in a serious car accident.
- 5 f. Feeling she doesn’t belong, she wants to quit before her first-year talk.
- 3 g. She completes her college degree four years later than her peers.

UNDERSTANDING KEY DETAILS

- A.** What do you think people mean when they tell Cuddy that they don't want to feel like "a fraud" or "an impostor"? Note down your answers and then discuss your ideas with a partner.

These people probably feel uncomfortable pretending to be something they are not. Cuddy's point though is that in pretending to be that something, you actually become it.

B. Watch (▶) the final segment of Cuddy's talk again.
Then answer the questions.



1. How did the graduate student feel before she came to talk to Cuddy?
 - a. She felt that she was going to fail.
 - ☒ b. She felt that she didn't belong there.

2. What did Cuddy tell the student to do?

to fake it

3. What was the outcome for that student?

She became more confident and the kind of student she wanted to be.

IDENTIFYING PURPOSE

Identifying the speaker's purpose is a good way to improve comprehension. Ask yourself questions as you listen. For example, "Why is the speaker sharing this? What does the speaker want me to understand?"

Why do you think Cuddy mentions the graduate student who came to see her? Choose the two best answers.

- a. To illustrate what a supportive teacher she was
- ☒ b. To reinforce the topic with an additional example
- ☒ c. To prove the point about "fake it till you make it"

SUMMARIZING

Summarize the conclusion of Amy Cuddy's talk using the words below.

high-power

outcomes

power-posing

powerless

Amy Cuddy wants people to try power-posing themselves, and also to share this science with others. She especially wants it to be shared with those who feel powerless. She ends the talk by reminding us that doing high-power poses for two minutes, in private, can truly change the outcome of a person's life.

CRITICAL THINKING

1. **Inferring.** What do you think Cuddy means when she says that the student “had actually faked it till she became it”?

In this case, the student did not just experience success at what she wanted to do, she changed her personality and became the type of high-power person that she wanted to be. As a result, she changed her life.

2. **Reasoning.** Which do you think is more important, that other people believe in us or that we believe in ourselves? Give reasons for your answer.

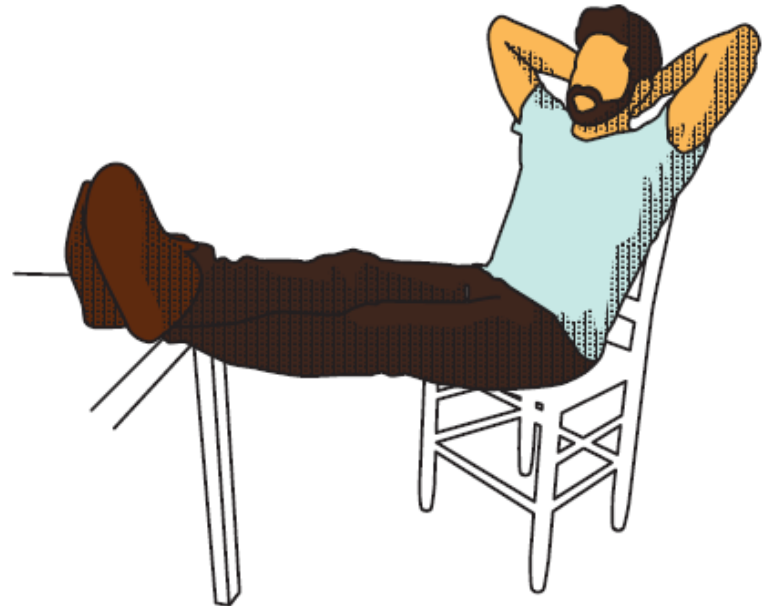
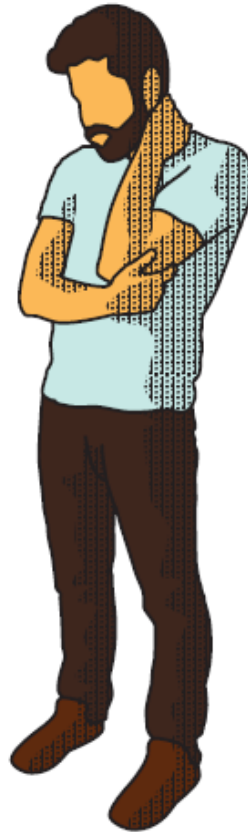
Answers will vary.

EXPLORE MORE

Watch Amy Cuddy's full TED Talk at TED.com. In her talk, Cuddy shares several more examples that demonstrate the power of nonverbal communication. Which one was most interesting to you, and why? Share your opinions with your class.

Project

High- and low-power poses. Can you guess which are which?



Project

A. Work in groups of five students. You are going to recreate Cuddy's experiment with low- and high-power poses.

1. In your group, prepare a short presentation about Amy Cuddy's research on power posing. Or, choose a topic from another unit.
2. Choose a student to be the judge. The judge should leave the room. Two students practice a high-power pose for two minutes; the other two students practice a low-power pose.
3. Ask the judge to come back in. Each student gives his or her presentation prepared in step 1.
4. The judge decides who did a high-power pose and who did a low-power pose.

Project

B. As a class, discuss the results of the experiment. Use the questions below.

- Were the judges correct?
- Did the low-power posers feel less confident?
- Did the high-power posers feel more confident?

EXPLORE MORE

Find out about the differences in nonverbal communication between various cultures. Is body language the same from culture to culture, or can you find any important differences? What are they? Share what you learn with your class.

Part 1

. . . So we're really fascinated with body language, and we're particularly interested in other people's body language. You know, we're interested in, like, you know, an awkward interaction, or a smile, or a contemptuous glance, or maybe a very awkward wink, . . .

So social scientists have spent a lot of time looking at the effects of our body language, or other people's body language, on judgments. And we make sweeping judgments and inferences from body language. And those judgments can predict really meaningful life outcomes, like who we hire or promote, who we ask out on a date. . . .

So when we think of nonverbals, we think of how we judge others, how they judge us, and what the outcomes are. We tend to forget, though, the other audience that's influenced by our nonverbals, and that's ourselves. . . .

Part 2

So my main collaborator Dana Carney, who's at Berkeley, and I really wanted to know, can you fake it till you make it? Like, can you do this just for a little while and actually experience a behavioral outcome that makes you seem more powerful? So we know that our nonverbals govern how other people think and feel about us. There's a lot of evidence. But our question really was, do our nonverbals govern how we think and feel about ourselves? . . .

So this is what we did. We decided to bring people into the lab and run a little experiment, and these people adopted, for two minutes, either high-power poses or low-power poses, and I'm just going to show you five of the poses, although they took on only two. So here's one. A couple more. This one has been dubbed the "Wonder Woman" by the media. Here are a couple more. So you can be standing or you can be sitting. And here are the low-power poses. So you're folding up, you're making yourself small. This one is very low-power. When you're touching your neck, you're really protecting yourself. So this is what happens. They come in, they spit into a vial, we for two minutes say, "You need to do this or this." They don't look at pictures of the poses. We don't want to prime them with a concept of power. We want them to be feeling power, right? So two minutes they do this. We then ask them, "How powerful do you feel?" on a series of items, and then we give them an opportunity to gamble, and then we take another saliva sample. That's it. That's the whole experiment.

So this is what we find. Risk tolerance, which is the gambling, what we find is that when you're in the high-power pose condition, 86 percent of you will gamble. When you're in the low-power pose condition, only 60 percent, and that's a pretty whopping significant difference.

Here's what we find on testosterone. From their baseline when they come in, high-power people experience about a 20-percent increase, and low-power people experience about a 10-percent decrease. So again, two minutes, and you get these changes. Here's what you get on cortisol. High-power people experience about a 25-percent decrease, and the low-power people experience about a 15-percent increase.

So two minutes lead to these hormonal changes that configure your brain to basically be either assertive, confident, and comfortable, or really stress-reactive, and, you know, feeling sort of shut down. And we've all had the feeling, right? So it seems that our nonverbals do govern how we think and feel about ourselves, so it's not just others, but it's also ourselves. Also, our bodies change our minds.

Part 3

. . . So when I tell people about this, that our bodies change our minds and our minds can change our behavior, and our behavior can change our outcomes, they say to me, “I don’t—It feels fake.” Right? So I said, “fake it till you make it.” “I don’t—It’s not me. I don’t want to get there and then still feel like a fraud. I don’t want to feel like an impostor. I don’t want to get there only to feel like I’m not supposed to be here.” And that really resonated with me, because I want to tell you a little story about being an impostor and feeling like I’m not supposed to be here.

When I was 19, I was in a really bad car accident. I was thrown out of a car, rolled several times. I was thrown from the car. And I woke up in a head injury rehab ward, and I had been withdrawn from college, and I learned that my I.Q. had dropped by two standard deviations, which was very traumatic.

I knew my I.Q. because I had identified with being smart, and I had been called gifted as a child. So I'm taken out of college, I keep trying to go back. They say, "You're not going to finish college. Just, you know, there are other things for you to do, but that's not going to work out for you." So I really struggled with this, and I have to say, having your identity taken from you, your core identity, and for me it was being smart, having that taken from you, there's nothing that leaves you feeling more powerless than that. So I felt entirely powerless. I worked and worked and worked, and I got lucky, and worked, and got lucky, and worked.

Eventually I graduated from college. It took me four years longer than my peers, and I convinced someone, my angel advisor, Susan Fiske, to take me on, and so I ended up at Princeton, and I was like, I am not supposed to be here. I am an impostor. And the night before my first-year talk, and the first-year talk at Princeton is a 20-minute talk to 20 people. That's it. I was so afraid of being found out the next day that I called her and said, "I'm quitting." She was like, "You are not quitting, because I took a gamble on you, and you're staying. You're going to stay, and this is what you're going to do. You are going to fake it. You're going to do every talk that you ever get asked to do. You're just going to do it and do it and do it, even if you're terrified and just paralyzed and having an out-of-body experience, until you have this moment where you say, 'Oh my gosh, I'm doing it. Like, I have become this. I am actually doing this.'" So that's what I did. . . .

So at the end of my first year at Harvard, a student who had not talked in class the entire semester, who I had said, “Look, you’ve gotta participate or else you’re going to fail,” came into my office. I really didn’t know her at all. And she said, she came in totally defeated, and she said, “I’m not supposed to be here.” And that was the moment for me. Because two things happened. One was that I realized, oh my gosh, I don’t feel like that anymore. You know. I don’t feel that anymore, but she does, and I get that feeling. And the second was, she is supposed to be here! Like, she can fake it, she can become it. So I was like, “Yes, you are! You are supposed to be here! And tomorrow you’re going to fake it, you’re going to make yourself powerful, and, you know, you’re gonna—” “And you’re going to go into the classroom, and you are going to give the best comment ever.” You know? And she gave the best comment ever, and people turned around and they were like, oh my God, I didn’t even notice her sitting there, you know?

She comes back to me months later, and I realized that she had not just faked it till she made it, she had actually faked it till she became it. So she had changed. And so I want to say to you, don't fake it till you make it. Fake it till you become it. . . .

So I want to ask you first, you know, both to try power posing, and also I want to ask you to share the science, because this is simple. I don't have ego involved in this. Give it away. Share it with people, because the people who can use it the most are the ones with no resources and no technology and no status and no power. Give it to them because they can do it in private. They need their bodies, privacy and two minutes, and it can significantly change the outcomes of their life.

Thank you.